

CONCERNS OF CONTROL
Students at the Indian Institute of Management, Ahmedabad

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NEW AMENDMENT BILL

TAMING THE IIMs

By Jumana Shah

The autonomy debate has returned to the Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs) after almost six years. In the past decade, the premier business schools frequently made headlines due to their struggle for autonomy, often overshadowing their international rankings and academic excellence. In December 2017, the IIM Autonomy Bill granted these institutions complete freedom in their functioning while the government continued to fund 16 of the 20 IIMs. This was hailed as a positive move by the IIM community. However, the proposed changes to the autonomy granted in 2017, through the Indian Institutes of Management (Amendment) Bill, 2023 passed by Parliament recently, have sparked controversy, with differing perspectives on the matter.

According to the new bill, the President will assume the role of Visitor on the board of governors of each IIM, with powers to nominate and remove the chairperson, oversee the appointment as well as removal of the director, and audit the functioning of the institution if necessary. While critics argue these amendments formalise political interference, another section claims that similar government powers existed before 2017, and the institutes